

The Ash Communion

A system agnostic toolkit for
Gathering stories from around the fire



There is a moment when nothing is trying to kill you.

It does not last long. It is not safe. It is only quiet.

This is the pause between outcomes. The ash after impact. The space where breath returns before it is taken again. No blades are drawn. No spells are cast. No clocks are advanced. The world waits, not out of mercy, but because it has already decided to continue.

This is when the questions begin.

Not explanations. Not confessions. Not absolution. Questions.

They are not meant to be answered cleanly. They are meant to be answered honestly, which is a different thing entirely. A lie is acceptable. Silence is acceptable. Deflection is acceptable. What is not acceptable is evasion without cost.

Someone speaks. It may be another traveler. It may be a stranger whose life has already collapsed. It may be no one at all—just the weight of the moment demanding to be filled. A question is asked as if it matters. As if the answer will be remembered. As if it could still change something.

It won't.

But it will be used.

This procedure exists to remind you that your character is not a collection of abilities waiting for activation. They are living history under pressure. They are a series of decisions that have not finished happening yet.

When the pause ends, the world resumes its work. What was said will not protect you. What was said will follow you.

Proceed carefully.

The Ash Communion

Use this when nothing is happening—and something should be.

This procedure may be invoked during rest, travel, captivity, aftermath, waiting, or any moment where the fiction slows. No rolls are made unless the system demands them. No mechanical benefit is granted by default.

This can be a cutscene or a pressure chamber.

Setup

- The group enters a temporary state of non-action
- Weapons may be held but not used
- Spells may be prepared but not cast
- The world is listening

Choose one of the following:

- A Speaker (GM or NPC) initiates the Communion
- The Table allows the silence to stretch until someone breaks it

Only one question exists at a time.

The Question

A question is asked in character.

The question must:

- Refer to the past, the self, or the future
- Assume history, damage, or consequence
- Be answerable without exposition

Good questions imply guilt, loss, or inevitability.

Bad questions ask for clarification, optimization, or lore dumps.

Examples:

- "Who taught you to survive like that?"
- "What did you promise yourself you wouldn't become?"
- "If this ends tonight, who doesn't get an apology?"
- "What are you pretending not to miss?"

Once asked, the question cannot be rephrased.

The Answer

The addressed character must respond.

They may:

- Answer directly
- Answer metaphorically
- Lie
- Deflect
- Remain silent

All responses are valid.

Silence is treated as an answer.

No one may interrupt or correct the response.

Doesn't trust healers

Consequence

(Implicit, Not Immediate)

Nothing mechanical happens now.

Instead:

- The GM writes the answer down.
- Another player remembers it
- The NPC reacts later
- The world incorporates it when convenient

What is said during the Communion becomes true enough to be used against the character later—by enemies, allies, or the fiction itself.

The player is not punished for honesty.

They are not protected from it either.

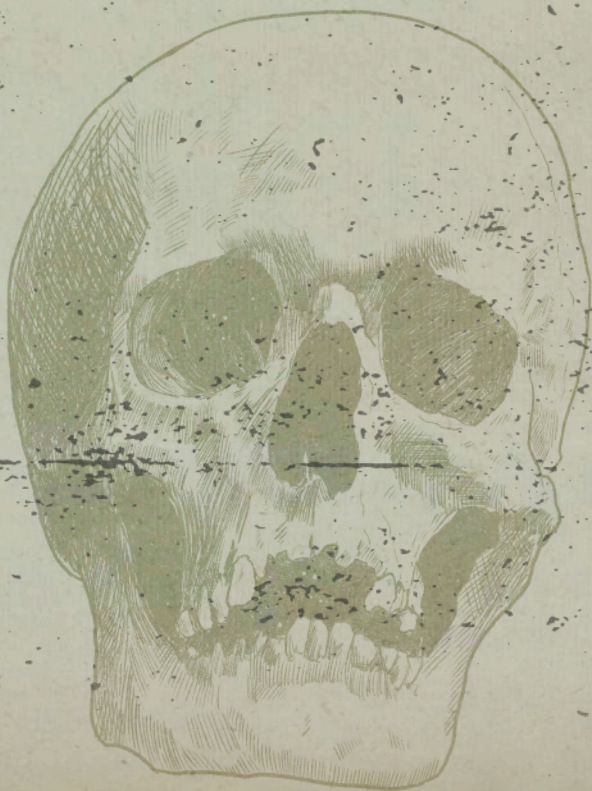
Ending The Pause

The Communion ends when every character has been asked one question.

When it ends, the world resumes without comment.

No recap is given.

No lesson is stated.



Purpose and Use

This procedure shifts play from capability to consequence.

Characters know what they can do. This asks what they have done, what they avoid, and what they expect to lose.

Answers are not judged for quality, drama, or usefulness. An answer that creates discomfort, contradiction, or uncertainty is working as intended.

For the GM, this is controlled leakage.

Every response creates material:

- Unfinished relationships
- Implied crimes
- Unspoken loyalties
- Future regrets
- Names that have not yet appeared in play

None of it needs to be used immediately, or at all. All of it is usable later.

Information revealed during the Communion may be reintroduced, twisted, leveraged, proven false, or proven worse than stated.

Listen more than you speak.

Players and Consequence

With consent, what is revealed by one character may be used by another.

It may become an alliance. Resentment. A shared secret. A fracture. A debt.

Remember what is said. Reference it later. Let it complicate things. Let relationships change from it.

Nothing said here is required to resolve cleanly.

*Church bell = Panic
Brother?*

Groundrules

Before using this procedure, agree on what stays off-screen.

A player may declare an answer closed. A player may ask that an answer not be used. A player may lie and never clarify.

All of these are valid.

If this procedure causes harm outside the fiction, stop. The world will provide other ways to suffer.

End State

When used well, the Communion produces:

Characters who feel inhabited

Relationships that feel unstable

Future scenes that write themselves

A world that remembers what the players said

If nothing comes of it immediately, that is normal.

Pressure takes time.

Post City - Nina's
Father was a soldier. Hated.

When and Why to Use This

This procedure is a blade.

Do not swing it constantly.

Do not dull it with comfort.

Use the Communion when:

- The group is drifting into mechanical play
- Characters feel interchangeable
- The fiction needs weight without violence
- You want future material without forcing plot

Do not use it:

- Every session
- To extract backstory on demand
- To punish players for honesty
- When the table is already emotionally raw

The Communion is not a reward.

It is not a trap.

It is an opportunity for the players to hand you weapons voluntarily.

Pace and Interruption

End the Communion early if:

- The table energy drops
- Answers become repetitive
- A real threat arrives

An interruption is not failure.

It reinforces the idea that the world does not wait for closure.

Failure Modes

You have used this wrong if:

- Players begin performing instead of responding
- Answers become jokes by default
- You are fishing for plot instead of listening
- The same character dominates every Communion

When this happens, stop using it for a while.

The Communion works because it is optional.

It works because it is remembered, do not rush to pay it off.

The world is patient, Be patient with it.

The Hunter's Cabin

Example Scenario

An example of how The Ash Communion begins.

The storm came fast.

Not unusual for the season, but onerous. The kind of rain that doesn't stop, doesn't soften, just settles in like it owns the air. The road became mud. The mud became a river. Forward progress became theoretical.

The cabin appeared through the trees like it had been waiting.

Hunters used it, probably. Or had used it. The door hung crooked. The thatch was mostly moss. But the walls were solid and the hearth still worked and the roof kept the sky where it belonged.

Kael got the fire going without asking permission.

He had that kind of face—the kind that expected small domestic tasks to fall to him. Not servile. Just practiced. Like he'd started fires in worse places than this and come out the other side functional.

The bottle surfaced from his pack twenty minutes later.

Wine that had the good sense of being available. He wiped the mouth with his sleeve, took a pull, stared at the fire long enough that one might think he died.

Then he spoke.

Kael's Monologue

"I had a daughter."

He said it to the room, and anyone who might be in it. Flat. Factual. Already distant.

"Not for long. Three years. Maybe four. I stopped counting after."

The fire cracked. He didn't look at anyone. Just the flames.

"Her mother wanted her raised proper. In the city. Where there were schools and physicians and people who'd teach her to curtsy instead of skin rabbits. I thought that was fine. I thought that was good, even. Better than what I could give her out here."

He took a gulp this time.

"Took her into the city when she was six. Got her enrolled in one of those church schools. The kind with stone floors and teachers who smell like incense and lies. They said she'd learn scripture. Latin. Manners."

Pause.

"What she learned was how to be quiet when the bishop's nephew came into the dormitory after lights out."

His voice didn't change. Same stale tone. Same distance. But his knuckles were white around the bottle.

"Found out two years later. She never said anything. The other girls never said anything. The teachers knew. The church knew. Everyone fucking knew. But the nephew's family donated the chapel's new bell, so."

He shrugged.

One shoulder. A defeated movement. The kind that means what can you do.

"Pulled her out. Brought her back here. Thought the woods would fix her. Thought distance would help. Thought if I just kept her away from cities and churches and people in robes she'd go back to being the kid who used to laugh at foxes."

The fire shifted. He fed it another log.

"She hung herself in the barn the week before her fourteenth birthday."

Silence.

Long enough to feel permanent.

Then he turns. Not to the group. To one person.

The one sitting closest. The one the others deferred to, even slightly. The one whose name got said first when decisions needed making.

He looks at them directly.

Not accusing. Not pleading. Just looking. The way you look at someone when you're about to ask something you're not sure you want answered.

"You ever have someone you were supposed to protect?"

He held the bottle out. Offering.

"Someone you failed?"

What Happens Next?

The player answers.

Or doesn't.

Or deflects.

Or takes the bottle and drinks and then answers.

Whatever they do, the ritual has begun.

Kael isn't demanding confession. He's offering it first. Modeling vulnerability. Showing that the fire is a safe place to say things you don't say in daylight.

If the player engages, Kael listens. Asks a follow-up question. Lets them go as deep as they want.

If they don't, he nods. Understands. Drinks again. Looks back at the fire.

But the offer stands.

The cabin is warm.

The rain isn't stopping.

The bottle is half full.

And there are other questions if anyone wants to answer them.

Owes a debt to Dave?

Love someone once. Fast time?

This is the tone.

Not forced.

Not theatrical.

Not a crying session.

Just: the weather trapped you here, someone got honest, and now the space exists for others to do the same if they want.

Kael's story is bait. It's permission. It's proof that saying the hard thing won't break the table.

What the players do with that permission is up to them.

Some will match it. Go deeper. Compete for rawness.

Some will deflect with humor. Acknowledge it but stay light.

Some will freeze. Not ready. Not tonight.

All of these are fine.

The Ash Communion isn't about extracting confessions.

It's about creating a moment where confession is possible.

The storm does the rest.

Polymorphed or real?

Flining and Integrating What's Said

When a player engages with the ritual—when they answer Kael's question or ask their own—you are being handed campaign infrastructure.

Listening Is the Job

When running this procedure, speak less.

Do not correct answers.

Do not clarify meaning.

Do not summarize for the table.

Write down:

- Names
- Places
- Half-finished thoughts
- Hesitations
- What the player avoids answering

These details are more valuable than dramatic speeches.

Apparently everybody loves Pie?

What to Listen for

Names

Every person mentioned is a potential NPC. Kael's daughter. The bishop's nephew. The mother who wanted her daughter raised proper. The teachers who knew and said nothing. Write them down. Some will stay ghosts. Some will walk into the campaign six sessions from now.

Places

The city with the church school. The barn. The woods Kael thought would fix things. Every location mentioned exists now. The player made it real by speaking it. You can use it. Send them back there. Have it burn down. Let them find it abandoned or thriving or occupied by something worse.

Allegiances

Who did the character trust? Who failed them? Who did they fail? These are fault lines. Pressure points. If a player says "I trusted the church once," you now know organized religion is a lever. If they say "I never trusted anyone in uniform," you know how they'll react to guards, soldiers, officials.

Wounds

What the player reveals as pain is what matters to their character. Kael's daughter is his wound. Whatever the player shares is theirs. Don't weaponize it immediately—that's cheap. But remember it. When the campaign reaches a moment of high stakes, when you need the player to feel something, reference the wound. Not directly. Obliquely. Let them recognize the shape of their own grief in someone else's story.

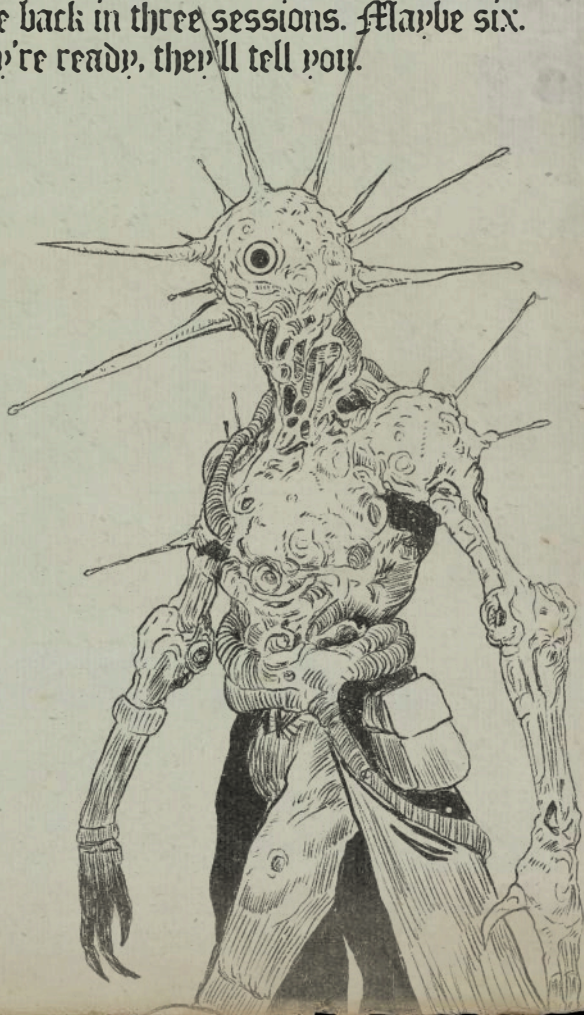
Debts and Guilt

"Someone you failed" is the question Kael asks, but the answer tells you what the character owes. Not to an NPC. To themselves. To their own conscience. This is fuel. Redemption arcs start here. Revenge arcs start here. Self-destruction starts here.

What They Don't Say

Pay attention to deflection. If a player dodges the question, that's information too. They're not ready to go there yet. Which means there exists. Note it. Circle back in three sessions. Maybe six. Give them time. When they're ready, they'll tell you.

Nightmares about drinking.



Using What You Have Been Given

Never resolve information from the Communion immediately.

Let it sit.

Let it rot.

If a player reveals their sister died in a factory fire, don't have a factory burn down next session. That's obvious. That's manipulative. That's the GM saying "I'm using your trauma for content."

Instead:

Wait.

Let the campaign breathe.

Then, three sessions later, introduce an NPC factory worker who mentions conditions are getting worse. Let the player connect the dots themselves. Let them decide if they care.

Or:

Six sessions later, the villain's plan involves a factory. The player will remember. The player will make it personal. You didn't force it. You just gave them space to recognise their own story.

"Death was not an escape."

Use it as background texture.

A player mentions they grew up in a port city. You weren't planning on using a port city. Now you are. Not as the main plot. Just as a location. A rumor. A place refugees are fleeing from. Let the player ask "Wait, which port?" Let them realize it's theirs.

Let other players build on it.

If one player mentions a dead sister and another player says "I had a sister too," let them connect. Maybe they're not related. Maybe the coincidence is just coincidence. Or maybe they realize their sisters knew each other. Died in the same place. Were killed by the same people.

You didn't plan this. The players built it. Let them.

Introduce NPCs organically.

Kael mentioned a bishop's nephew. Four sessions from now, the party is in a different city and someone introduces himself as a bishop's aide. Different diocese. Different person. But the type is the same. Let the player who heard Kael's story react. Let them decide if this person is guilty by association or innocent until proven complicit.

Use places as emotional anchors.

A player mentions the village they grew up in. Later, the campaign takes them near it. You don't force them to go. You just mention it's two days east. Close enough to visit. Close enough to avoid.

Let them choose.

If they go, it's meaningful.

If they don't, that's meaningful too.

"Clown town"

Don't make everything about trauma.

Not every hook needs to be pain. If a player mentions they used to love baking bread, maybe they smell fresh bread in a city and it reminds them of something good for once. Maybe an NPC baker gives them a loaf and asks nothing in return.

Hooks aren't just leverage. They're texture. They're proof the character existed before the campaign started, or after.

Later, when appropriate:

- Introduce an NPC who contradicts the story
- Echo a phrase back at the character
- Reveal consequences they did not anticipate
- Offer a choice that mirrors their answer

If a player says, "I don't care what happens to me,"
believe them just enough to test it.

In this necronomy?!

Weaponizing the Moment

(Handle With Care)

You may, sparingly:

- Ask a follow-up question later in the campaign
- Reframe an answer as rumor or accusation
- Force a character to act in contradiction to what they said

Never:

- Mock an answer
- Reduce it to a mechanical penalty
- Reveal private notes without consent

If a player trusts you with something real,
treat it like live ammunition.

What the Table Gains

After the Ash Communion, you have:

- A dozen names you didn't have before
- Locations the players care about
- New NPCs the players already have opinions on
- Emotional stakes the players volunteered
- Connections between characters you can build on
- Proof that these characters are people, not stat blocks with backstories stapled on

The campaign becomes collaborative.

Not in a forced "everyone build the world together" way.

In a "you told me what mattered, so I'm weaving it in" way.

The players feel seen.

The world feels personal.

The table becomes invested.

Common Mistakes

Using it too soon.

If you immediately turn a player's confession into a plot hook, it feels exploitative. Like you were farming them for content. Wait. Let it breathe. Let them forget they told you. Then use it when it fits naturally.

Using it too heavy-handed.

Don't make every session about their trauma. Don't turn the campaign into therapy. Let their backstory be background until the moment it's not. Then let it land.

Ignoring what they said.

If a player shares something and you never reference it, they'll stop sharing. Not dramatically. Just quietly. They'll realize the ritual was performative and their answers didn't matter. Don't do that. Even a small callback—an NPC name, a location mentioned in passing—shows you were listening.

Forcing everyone to match intensity.

If one player goes deep and another stays light, let them. Not everyone needs to trauma-dump. Not everyone needs to share. The ritual works even if only one person engages fully and the others just listen.

Flaking it about your plot.

The Ash Communion is not a tool for getting players to care about your story. It's a tool for discovering their story so you can weave it into the campaign. If you're only listening for ways to hook them into your pre-written arc, you're doing it wrong.

